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Beyond the Right Answer: Balancing Didaktik, Student Agency, and Authentic Assessment in Higher Education

Group Critical Analysis Essay

Abstract

This essay critically examines whether higher education can foster independent judgment while maintaining clear learning objectives and credible assessment. Drawing on Magnússon and Rytzler's (2022) account of Didaktik, research on constructive alignment and formative assessment, and five students' reflective notes, it argues that educational structure and intellectual freedom are complementary only when assessment makes students' reasoning visible. The reflections reveal tensions between teacher authority and responsiveness, participation and uncertainty, and measurable achievement and genuine understanding. They also raise concerns about evaluating learning when generative artificial intelligence can produce convincing academic work. The analysis proposes dialogic teaching, explicit but revisable criteria, formative feedback, and staged authentic assessment. To complement these qualitative reflections, a 10-item Likert-scale survey conducted among master's students provides empirical validation regarding course structure, participation anxiety, and the challenges of AI-driven assessment. The central conclusion of this essay highlights the need for universities to adopt assessment approaches that evaluate the way students respond, question, justify, revise and apply their knowledge, along with finishing assessments.

Introduction

University teaching is often judged through learning outcomes, grades, and graduates' employability. These indicators provide useful accountability, but they do not fully capture curiosity, intellectual independence, or the capacity to challenge assumptions. Magnússon and Rytzler (2022), particularly in Chapters 8 and 9 of Towards a Pedagogy of Higher Education, challenge instrumental views of teaching and reconsider the university as a place of study rather than merely a producer of predefined results. Their discussion of Didaktik foregrounds the relationship among teacher, student, and subject matter, as well as the dilemmas that arise when educators attempt to influence learning without controlling it.

This essay argues that effective university pedagogy requires a defensible balance between educational guidance and students' freedom to think independently. The argument combines scholarly literature with five student reflections by Tuzelova, Khamidulla, Zholtaev, Nurlybekova, and Pernesh, alongside quantitative survey data ($N = 22$) from Master's students in Applied Artificial Intelligence. These reflections offer situated student perspectives, not a representative survey. The analysis first evaluates Didaktik alongside constructive alignment, then compares students' experiences of teaching and participation, and finally considers how assessment should respond to generative AI.

Critical Analysis: Educational Purpose, Structure, and Uncertainty

Magnússon and Rytzler (2022) identify a tension between higher education understood through measurable learning outcomes and teaching understood as an educational relationship. Didaktik redirects attention from transmitting content to how teachers select subject matter, respond to particular students, and create conditions for study. Its strength is that it acknowledges education's unpredictability: the same explanation may support one learner while limiting another. However, the approach can be difficult to operationalize. If responsiveness is interpreted simply as teacher discretion, students may encounter unclear standards or unequal treatment.

Biggs's (1996) constructive alignment offers a productive counterpoint. By connecting intended outcomes, learning activities, and assessment, it helps teachers clarify what students should be able to demonstrate. Its practical strength is coherence: students are less likely to face examinations unrelated to what they practiced. Yet alignment can become restrictive when every worthwhile intellectual development is reduced to an assessable performance. A carefully designed course should therefore specify essential disciplinary competencies while leaving space for unexpected questions and alternative interpretations. Didaktik supplies a critical account of educational purpose, whereas alignment offers an organizational tool; neither is sufficient alone.

This distinction also concerns the purposes of university education. Biesta (2009) separates qualification, socialization, and subjectification, arguing that educational quality cannot be settled through measurements alone. Qualification matters in technical degrees, but subjectification - students becoming capable of responsible judgment - cannot be inferred from test scores. In her reflection, Nurlybekova similarly questions treating university study only as preparation for employment. The limitation of this position is that personal growth can become a vague ideal unless educators explain how it is cultivated and recognized. Its

value lies in insisting that employability should be an outcome of education, not its complete definition.

Comparison: Teacher Authority and Student Participation

The reflections demonstrate why a single teaching method is unlikely to work universally. Zholtaev contrasts a strict, fair mathematics teacher with an approachable chemistry teacher. Initially, stronger memories of mathematics seemed to favor strictness. He subsequently recognized a confounding factor: he had spent much more time revisiting mathematics for examinations and university study. This self-correction is important because it distinguishes a memorable experience from evidence of instructional effectiveness. Neither discipline nor friendliness can be declared superior from the anecdote alone.

Khamidulla, meanwhile, describes a classroom activity organized around raising questions rather than simply covering a topic. He perceived active discussion as more meaningful learning. His account supports the Didaktik emphasis on participation, but participation should not be equated automatically with understanding. Students may contribute frequently while repeating misconceptions, and quieter learners may reflect deeply without speaking. Zholtaev also admits that he sometimes remains silent until he can formulate a perfect contribution. Together, these accounts suggest that the teacher must invite participation without making spontaneous speech the sole measure of engagement.

Tuzelova articulates the underlying paradox: teachers are responsible for learning but cannot determine exactly how students will understand. Her example from artificial intelligence is instructive: a model may obtain high predictive accuracy while its decisions remain difficult to explain. Likewise, a student can reproduce a correct answer without being able to justify it. Nevertheless, complete uncertainty is not inherently productive. Beginners often need worked examples, clear explanations, and explicit expectations before they can question material responsibly. Effective teaching should progressively shift responsibility to students, rather than choose between instruction and discovery as mutually exclusive approaches.

Pernesh's reflection on emancipatory teaching adds an important ethical perspective. Drawing on class discussions of Mollenhauer and Rancière, she distinguishes teachers' authority to select meaningful material from a claim of intellectual superiority. She prefers a clear explanation and simple example before working independently, yet questions when this support becomes dependence. The dilemma is not resolved by rejecting explanations: initial guidance can make a subject accessible while students remain responsible for developing and defending their interpretations. Pernesh also connects Todd's emphasis on listening to her concern for hesitant students. Her point challenges discussion-based teaching: inviting contributions is insufficient unless educators take them seriously, accommodate different levels of confidence, and avoid speaking for students.

Critical Analysis: Assessment and the Challenge of Generative AI

Assessment makes the tension between visible performance and actual understanding particularly urgent. Nurlybekova distinguishes diagnostic, formative, and summative assessment and favors constructive feedback over grades alone. Research supports the educational importance of feedback: Nicol and Macfarlane-Dick (2006) argue that formative assessment can strengthen self-regulation when students evaluate their work and act upon

information, rather than passively receive judgments. Boud and Falchikov (2006) extend this argument by emphasizing assessment practices that prepare graduates to judge their own learning beyond the university. Their position is especially relevant to the reflections' common concern with independent thought.

However, formative assessment is not automatically superior to summative assessment. Feedback that is generic, delayed, or impossible to use may achieve little. Conversely, well-designed summative tasks can demand serious conceptual integration. The relevant distinction is therefore not grades versus no grades, but whether evidence of achievement captures meaningful learning and whether students can use assessment to improve. A course can combine low-stakes diagnostic questions, draft feedback, peer review, and a final performance evaluated against transparent criteria.

Generative AI complicates the validity of conventional take-home assignments. Nurlybekova asks how universities can assess independent thinking when AI tools can answer questions and complete assignments; Tuzelova raises a parallel concern about confusing a successful output with explainable reasoning. Fischer et al. (2024), studying 118 postgraduate management students in one educational setting, found that students often used generative AI for writing-related tasks rather than advanced critical sensemaking. This finding does not prove that all AI use reduces understanding, but it challenges the assumption that polished text demonstrates mastery.

Prohibiting AI entirely would also be inadequate because students must learn to evaluate the tools they may encounter professionally. A more defensible response is to distinguish permitted assistance from assessed intellectual responsibility. For example, students might submit a research question and rationale, annotated evidence, a draft with recorded revisions, and a final argument, followed by a short oral explanation of their decisions. Authentic projects, case studies, and presentations, proposed in Nurlybekova's reflection, can strengthen validity when the teacher also checks individual contributions. Yet these tasks require more time, consistent rubrics, and safeguards for students who experience anxiety during oral assessment.

Relevance: From Theoretical Tensions to University Practice

The strongest insight across the literature and reflections is that responsible teaching is neither complete control nor unstructured freedom. Biggs (1996) helps align a course around what learners should do; Magnússon and Rytzler (2022) remind educators to ask why those activities matter and how teaching may transform students' relation to knowledge. Biesta's (2009) broader educational purposes explain why technical proficiency should coexist with judgment. The peer reflections illustrate these connections through questions about fairness, participation, explanation, attentive listening, and assessment.

A practical approach would involve three linked design decisions. First, teachers should formulate outcomes such as 'evaluate competing explanations using evidence' rather than merely 'identify the correct answer.' Second, activities should combine concise instruction, questions, individual reflection, and structured turn-taking so hesitant students have time to formulate and explain their ideas. Third, assessments should reward accurate disciplinary knowledge together with transparent reasoning, justified revisions, and responsible AI

disclosure. Formative feedback can then address the gap between a student's argument and disciplinary standards without demanding that all students think identically.

Such a design still faces constraints. Large classes, workload, limited time, and inconsistent marking can undermine individualized teaching. Rubrics improve fairness but may unintentionally narrow original responses; open discussion supports agency but can privilege confident speakers. A workable compromise is to use shared criteria for the quality of justification while permitting different defensible conclusions. Students can demonstrate their learning through alternative formats when the same underlying competence is assessed.

Empirical Evidence: Focus Group Survey

To complement the qualitative student reflections and test their alignment with the broader student experience, a 10-item quantitative survey was conducted among N = 22 Master's students in Applied Artificial Intelligence (AAI) at Astana IT University. The survey utilized a 5-point Likert scale (1 = Strongly Disagree to 5 = Strongly Agree) to examine students' perceptions of educational purpose, pedagogical authority, grading fairness, and the validity of assessment in an AI-saturated context.

The quantitative findings align closely with the core theoretical arguments of the essay:

1. Structure vs. Agency: While 86.4% of respondents agreed that the main purpose of university is to cultivate critical thinking rather than purely vocational training (Item 1, Mean = 4.00), an overwhelming 95.5% indicated that clear learning outcomes and structured requirements help them learn better than unstructured freedom (Item 2, Mean = 4.45). This confirms the essay's premise that constructive alignment provides a necessary framework within which student agency can develop.
2. Pedagogical Authority and Inclusivity: 81.8% of students affirmed that clear explanations and worked examples are prerequisites for independent critical work (Item 3, Mean = 4.18). Furthermore, while active discussion was valued (86.4% agreement, Item 4, Mean = 4.14), 68.2% noted that grading live participation often disadvantages students who require time to process their thoughts before speaking (Item 5, Mean = 3.95).
3. Assessment and AI Validity: A significant majority (72.7%) favored detailed formative feedback over simple numerical grades (Item 6, Mean = 4.09). Crucially, 59.1% disagreed that final grades accurately reflect genuine understanding (Item 7, Mean = 2.77). Regarding generative AI, 68.2% agreed that a polished essay can no longer serve as reliable evidence of independent critical thinking (Item 9, Mean = 3.95), and 77.3% advocated for staged authentic assessment that evaluates process, revisions, and oral defenses rather than merely final submissions (Item 10, Mean = 4.09).

Limitations

The empirical findings from both the five student reflections and the focus group survey (N = 22) provide meaningful insights into how Master's students in Applied Artificial Intelligence perceive higher education pedagogy and assessment. However, several

methodological limitations must be acknowledged. First, the survey sample is relatively small and confined to a single cohort within a specific discipline (Applied AI), which may reflect specialized technical perspectives and familiarity with AI capabilities that differ from students in non-technical or humanities disciplines.

Second, the reflective notes represent qualitative, self-reported accounts, while the survey captures cross-sectional perceptions rather than direct observations of actual learning outcomes. While the survey data successfully validates the reflective themes regarding structured guidance, participation anxiety, and the erosion of traditional assessment validity under generative AI, it does not establish formal causal relationships between specific teaching methods and academic achievement. To further generalize these conclusions across higher education, future research should employ larger, multi-disciplinary samples, combine quantitative metrics with longitudinal tracking, and incorporate external peer or instructor evaluations.

Conclusion

The analysis suggests that the central question in higher education is not whether teachers should provide structure or independence, but how they can make both educationally valuable. Didaktik challenges the reduction of teaching to predictable outcomes, while constructive alignment helps prevent intellectual freedom from becoming confused. Both the qualitative reflections and the empirical survey ($N = 22$) show that students value fairness, clear explanation, attentive listening, discussion, and feedback, yet also confront silence, uncertainty, and the misleading appearance of competence. In an AI-rich environment, these tensions become more visible: a polished response is not necessarily evidence of understanding.

Universities should therefore combine purposeful guidance with dialogic study and assessments that reveal reasoning over time. The most important learning developed through this comparison is that educational quality lies not simply in correct answers but in students' growing ability to explain, question, revise, and defend them.

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